

HAVE WE BEEN ASSIMILATED?

Are we really “The Borg” or is this just another rubbish headline?

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As geeks, we're all invested in some space fantasy or the other, because love of science fiction is one of the most common geek traits. Now, we all know that *Star Wars* and *Star Trek* are the two most famous space-based science fiction sagas out there, though many will insist that only *Star Trek* is science-fiction while *Star Wars* is pure fantasy and no science – let's not have a USS Enterprise vs Millennium Falcon dog-fight just yet. Let's just agree that *Star Trek* is meant to be a more accurate a prediction of our future as a space faring species, while *Star Wars* is “A long time ago in a galaxy far, far away....” and doesn't even deal with humans.

TECHNOLOGY: GOOD OR EVIL?

While so much of sci-fi involves technology being used more for evil than for good, and it's the basic plot of hits such as the *Terminator* series or the *Matrix* trilogy, it was *Star Trek* that first made it cool to be a geek, and made engineers and scientists into heroes. The original series did have the brash, lady-charming, and not-so-scientific Captain James T Kirk as the main hero, but it also had the medical advice of Leonard Bones McCoy as the doctor and Spock the always logical Vulcan.

Star Trek looked at a future where technology was just another tool that humans used to achieve things, and

they did so matter of factly, without fanfare or trying to hero the technology. Now I know a lot of you might want to hero the features of your latest phone, but *Star Trek* aimed far beyond our petty egos and tried to imagine a future where technology was just taken for granted and where humans had no other purpose except to learn more about our universe, and have philosophical conversations about the fate of lesser species that were encountered by them.

Counter this with *Terminator* or *The Matrix* where technology is basically only trying to wipe humans out, or

farm them for food, and you can see that *Star Trek* was far more optimistic and realistic than the others. Of course, people like Elon Musk and the late Stephen Hawking have disagreed in the past, suggesting that AI will eventually try to destroy us... but that's a completely different discussion.

And it's not like *Star Trek* was only always optimistic about technology and its use, and never explored the evil side of technology, because they did come up with one of the most relentless villains in the history of science fiction. The Borg were something that all *Star Trek* fans were taught to hate instantly. They went against everything that was human, and were the very definition of evil technology, as it was being used to subjugate and take over entire species.

According to *Star Trek*, the Borg are a once very human-like species that are obsessed with perfecting themselves, and part of perfecting themselves is to embrace technology and assimilate the technologies of species they come into contact with. Of course, it also means assimilating the species themselves... men, women, children, all... in order to assimilate the knowledge of the species.

Sound familiar? If you really think about it, doesn't that sound just like us? We're not doing it across species yet, but across countries and geographical regions we're certainly using



The Borg – villains in Hollywood, but just us in the future